

Forming a New Congregation

Meeting guide and S-51 preparation checklist

Source: Congregation Application/Information (S-51-E), revision 1/16, pages 1-2

Start with this important limitation

S-51 says to read the **Instructions for Recommending New Congregations (S-50)** before completing the application. This guide captures what S-51 requires, but **S-51 alone is not the complete recommendation procedure**. Obtain and review the current S-50 before finalising or submitting anything.

The meeting outcome

By the end of the meeting, aim to have these six results:

1. **A clear reason** for recommending the new congregation.
2. **The congregations and territory involved** identified.
3. **A suitable proposed complete name** checked against the naming rules.
4. **Accurate publisher and appointed-brother counts** for every required S-51 form.
5. **A realistic proposed start month** and the circuit overseer’s circuit-and-section recommendation.
6. **Owners and deadlines** for the forms, map or explanation, review, and signatures.

At a glance

We need to prepare	What goes on its S-51
Proposed new congregation	Points 1-8 ; leave the congregation-number field blank
Existing congregation whose boundary is affected	Points 1-4
Existing congregation hosting the group	Points 1-4
Existing congregation whose only change is its name	Point 1 only

Prepare one S-51 for the proposed new congregation and one for **each** existing congregation directly involved.

Suggested meeting flow

Part	Main question	Decision or information to record
1. Confirm the procedure	Do we have the current S-50 and understand who must be involved?	Any procedural questions to resolve
2. Establish the reason	Why would a new congregation be beneficial and workable?	Short factual explanation for point 5
3. Define the effect	Which territories and congregations are directly involved?	Complete names, numbers, and boundary/hosting impact
4. Choose a name	What name accurately reflects the proposed territory?	Proposed complete name and any needed explanation
5. Confirm resources	Who will make up and serve the congregation?	Publisher, pioneer, elder, and ministerial-servant counts
6. Confirm readiness	When could it begin, and where should it be assigned?	First of proposed month/year; circuit and section
7. Assign next actions	Who will prepare, verify, and sign each item?	Owners and due dates

S-51 data checklist

1. Proposed complete name

Record the proposed new congregation's:

- directional or geographic designation;
- city;
- province or state; and
- congregation number — **leave this blank for the new congregation.**

If an existing congregation involved in the proposal needs a new name, record both its current complete name and its proposed new complete name.

2. Publishers, including pioneers

Record the form's three requested figures:

- total active;
- regular; and
- baptized.

Use the categories exactly as they appear on the form and verify the figures before submission.

3. Pioneers

Record:

- regular pioneers; and
- special pioneers.

4. Appointed brothers

Record how many will serve as:

- elders; and
- ministerial servants.

Points 5-8 are for the proposed new congregation only

Do not complete points 5-8 on the S-51 forms for the existing congregations involved.

5. Reason for forming the congregation

Prepare a brief, factual statement explaining why the new congregation is being recommended. If the form does not provide enough space, continue on page 2.

Discussion prompts: What present situation is the proposal addressing? How will the proposed arrangement affect the congregations and territory involved? What facts support the recommendation?

6. Existing congregations directly involved

List:

- every congregation whose territory boundary would be affected; and
- the congregation that has been hosting the group, if a hosted group is now being recommended as a congregation.

For each one, provide its **complete name** — including directional or geographic designation, city, and province or state — and its congregation number. Additional congregations may be listed on page 2.

7. Proposed start

State when the new congregation could begin functioning: **the first of a month and year.**

8. Circuit and section

The **circuit overseer** recommends the circuit and section to which the congregation should be assigned.

Date and signatures shown on the application

The S-51 application provides fields for the date and typed-name signatures of:

- coordinator of the body of elders;
- secretary;
- circuit overseer; and
- service overseer.

For a name change that is **not** connected with forming a new congregation, S-51 says that only point 1 is completed and the form need only be signed by the Congregation Service Committee.

Naming guide

The three-part name

A complete congregation name should reflect its territory assignment and contain:

Part	Requirement	Check
1	A directional or other geographic designation — such as a street, park, or neighbourhood	☐
2	A city within the congregation's territory	☐
3	The province or state containing that city	☐

The directional or geographic designation must relate to the **city named in the complete name**, not to a neighbouring city. The city name itself should not be used as the first part.

S-51 example: “Hamilton Congregation of Jehovah’s Witnesses, Bath, Maine.”

If the congregation uses a foreign language

When the congregation’s primary language differs from the country’s principal language:

- include the language in the first part of the complete name; and
- put a directional or geographic designation before the language, even if it is the only congregation of that language in the city.

S-51 example: “Hamilton Spanish Congregation of Jehovah’s Witnesses, Bath, Maine.”

Check whether an existing congregation should request a name change

When a second congregation is formed, the original congregation’s name does **not** change automatically. It should request permission to change its name if:

- its current name will no longer reflect a meaningful part of its revised territory; or
- the first part of its name is only a language and another congregation of the same language is being formed in that city.

If the reason for the selected name is not clearly visible on the map sent to the branch office, provide a brief explanation of why the name is appropriate.

Once approved, always use the complete three-part name in branch correspondence, letterheads, bank accounts, exemption applications, and similar official uses.

Meeting worksheet

A. Proposed new congregation

Item	Working answer
Directional/geographic designation	
City	
Province/state	
Reason the name fits the territory	
Primary language, if different from the country’s principal language	
Proposed first month/year of operation	
Recommended circuit and section — circuit overseer	

B. People and support

S-51 figure	Count	Verified by
Total active publishers, including pioneers		
Regular		
Baptized		
Regular pioneers		
Special pioneers		
Elders who will serve		
Ministerial servants who will serve		

C. Existing congregations directly involved

Complete congregation name	Number	Boundary affected, hosting group, or name only?	S-51 needed
			☐
			☐
			☐
			☐

D. Draft reason for the recommendation

E. Actions after the meeting

Action	Owner	Due date	Done
Obtain and review the current S-50			☐
Confirm proposed boundaries and the map required by the applicable instructions			☐
Verify all publisher and pioneer figures			☐
Verify elder and ministerial-servant assignments/counts			☐
Confirm every involved congregation and its complete name/number			☐
Check the proposed name against all S-51 naming rules			☐
Draft the point 5 explanation			☐
Prepare the new congregation's S-51, points 1-8			☐
Prepare each other required S-51 with the correct points			☐
Obtain the required typed-name signatures			☐
Conduct final review against S-50 and S-51			☐

Accuracy note: This is a plain-language meeting aid, not a replacement for S-50 or S-51. Where this guide and the official instructions differ, follow the current official instructions.